N. CHANDRABABU NAIDU 74
Chief Minister, Andhra Pradesh

THE COMEBACK KING

It was in no one's script: Naidu's standing leap from near-oblivion, to a place where he writes the destiny of Andhra—even New Delhi

By Amarnath K. Menon

Not too far behind the Indian republic, Nara Chandrababu Naidu will himself turn 75. He was born in April 1950, just three months after the country moved to being a modern electoral democracy. In 2024, a year shy of his landmark, the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) supremo was proving to be one of its contemporary marvels. He was already into his 49th year in politics, having been blooded as a Youth Congress colt in 1975—the halcyon days of Sanjay Gandhi's Emergency-era dominance—winning his first assembly seat in 1978, one of the local young turks of the Grand Old Party at age 28, and seeing his first ministerial portfolio by 1980. And here he was, staging a stunning political pirouette, taking a standing leap from near-oblivion right back to hegemonic sway, with more than a ringside role in the melting-pot politics of New Delhi—and a return to a capital of his dreams closer home.

Under ordinary circumstances, the back story would have warranted a retirement home: nearly a decade as the arch-reformist chief minister of undivided Andhra Pradesh in another era (1995-2004), and five years as the first CM of the residuary state (2014-19). After that, he looked spent. The TDP won only 23 out of 175 seats in the 2019 assembly poll, and a young rival ruled the Andhra lands, strutting about on the coast and upcountry. Only trouble was, there was to be no soft sunset worthy of a long career. Old age was more black than silver and gold: 2021 saw a teary walkout from the assembly after abusive remarks against his wife, and 2023 marked the nadir with 53 days in the Rajahmundry Central Prison.

The comeback may only be the beginning of a new story. Call it Naidu 4.0. It's a bold plan to transform Andhra from coastal farm country into a glittering, global tech hub

